

SHELTER CAPACITY IS A FOSTER PROBLEM

The Foster Pack

A shelter system of record that grows foster capacity — by fixing onboarding, holding on to beginner fosters, and turning every placement into organic reach.

Launch partner: San Francisco SPCA · Replaces PetPoint as system of record · PRD v0.1

Shelters can't build kennels fast enough. They can build foster homes.

01 Kennel capacity is fixed. Foster capacity is elastic — and badly run.

Every shelter already has more willing fosters than it can onboard, match, and keep.

02 The bottleneck isn't willingness. It's the first 72 hours.

30–50% of new fosters never take a second placement. That is the capacity leak.

03 No existing system owns the foster lifecycle.

Incumbents model fostering as a status field on an animal record. It is a human retention problem.

04 We own the record, so we can fix the funnel.

Onboard in under 24 hours, coach beginners through week one, and turn each placement into recruitment reach.

5.8M animals entered US shelters last year.

Large dogs are staying longer than ever. A third of shelters are operating above practical capacity. Foster homes are the only way to make more room this quarter.

2.8M

dogs entered US shelters

Down 2% year over year

320K

dogs euthanized annually

Space and length-of-stay lead the causes

1 in 3

shelters above capacity

Despite 68% meeting no-kill benchmarks

30–50%

of new fosters never return

The single largest source of lost capacity

Sources: Shelter Animals Count 2025 Annual Data Report · ASPCA US Animal Shelter Statistics · Best Friends 2025 National Shelter Data Report · Maddie's Fund foster turnover research.

Rescue capacity = kennels + foster homes.

KENNELS — FIXED

Capital budget. Zoning. Construction. Hiring. Measured in years and millions of dollars.

A building expansion cannot respond to a July intake surge.

FOSTER HOMES — ELASTIC

Capacity that already exists, unused, inside the community. No capital cost.

Activated in days — if onboarding, matching, and support actually work.

A shelter that adds 30 durable foster homes creates more usable capacity than a multi-million-dollar building expansion — and does it this quarter.

Three compounding failures.

Each one makes the next worse. Together they cap how many dogs a shelter can move through foster care.

P1

There is no foster or volunteer database.

No queryable roster of who is available, what they're qualified for, how far they'll travel, or how reliable they've been. Every placement and every unscheduled vet run is brokered by one exhausted human through group texts and memory.

P2

The dog's story is fragmented across systems never built to hold it.

PetPoint tracks intake and outcome. It has nowhere to put what the foster actually sees — she panics at skateboards, he settles instantly in a crate. That narrative is the strongest predictor of adoption fit, and it evaporates at every handoff.

P3

Institutional knowledge is never shared.

A first-time foster whose dog starts sneezing at 9pm has no fast path to an answer. Experienced fosters, volunteers, and staff collectively know it — nothing connects them.

The foster funnel leaks at every stage.

Stage	What happens today	The leak
Acquisition	Word of mouth, an occasional Instagram post, a table at an adoption event	Shelters recruit from the same small pool. Reach is unmeasured and unowned.
Application & onboarding	PDF packets, home checks, email tag, orientation scheduling	Programs requiring home checks report ~74% fewer foster placements.
First placement	Approved fosters wait days to weeks for a match	The fastest-growing foster programs match a new foster within 24 hours.
First 72 hours	Foster is alone with a frightened dog that won't eat	The single highest churn moment. Nothing normalises a wobbly week one.
Retention	No structure after placement #1; contact is ad hoc or absent	30–50% never foster again. Volunteer turnover runs 30–40% per year.
Experienced fosters	Broadcast texts and bulk email to everyone, always	Over-notification is the top churn risk for the fosters you can least afford to lose.

Sources: Maddie’s Fund National Foster Survey and foster caregiver turnover study · Journal of Applied Animal Welfare Science (2024), Dog Foster Volunteer Retention.

USERS

Six people. One record.

Every persona has a different failure mode. The product's job is to serve all six without letting any one of them churn.

Foster — Beginner

TIER 1

First or second placement. Enthusiastic, anxious, unsure what's normal.

Churns if abandoned — or if the app nags.

Foster — Intermediate

TIER 2

Several placements. Knows the basics, takes moderately complex cases.

Wants milestones, not hand-holding.

Foster — Experienced

TIER 3

Medical, behavioural, neonate and hospice cases. The scarce resource.

Over-notification is the primary churn risk.

Volunteer

TIME-CONSTRAINED

Wants to help concretely: transport, supply runs, photography, walks.

Frustrated by 'can anyone do X?' broadcast texts.

Shelter Admin / Coordinator

THE CONSTRAINT

Dozens of dogs, hundreds of people, lives in the web dashboard.

Needs exceptions surfaced, not a firehose.

Veterinarian / Vet Tech

LIGHT-TOUCH

Reads foster-observed history before an appointment, appends a summary.

Must never be asked to learn a new EMR.

THE CHURN MOMENT

The first 72 hours decide whether you ever get a second placement.

HOUR 0

TODAY

Dog goes home with a printed care sheet.

HOUR 8

She won't eat. Foster panics, texts the coordinator.

DAY 2

No reply yet. Foster googles, finds contradictory advice.

DAY 3

Foster returns the dog and quietly never comes back.

WITH THE FOSTER PACK

Pre-arrival checklist done. Mentor foster already introduced.

Prompt: 'Lots of dogs won't eat day one. Did she eat today?'

One tap on 'Something's wrong' → coordinator alerted, triage offered.

First-meal milestone celebrated, shareable. Foster asks for dog #2.

Beginner retention is not a loyalty problem. It is a week-one support problem, and it is automatable.

MARKET ANALYSIS

13,471 US shelters and rescues. None of them have this.

TAM

13,471 orgs

All US shelters (4,100) and rescue groups (9,371).
US shelter software spend runs \$100–120M and grows 5–7% a year.

\$100–120M

SAM

~6,100 orgs

Shelters plus foster-heavy rescues that run a structured foster programme — the ones with a coordinator to give back.

\$12–30M ARR

SOM

50 tenants

The platform's own engineering design target.
West Coast metro shelters seeded by the SFSPCA reference.

\$0.4–1.2M ARR

Pricing follows nonprofit norms (\$1.2K–\$10K/yr per org). Mission funding — Maddie's Fund, Petco Love, Best Friends — is a credible second revenue line, and capacity outcomes are exactly what those grants fund.

Sources: Shelter Animals Count / ASPCA organisation counts (2025) · vendor pricing disclosures for Shelterluv, PetPoint, Chameleon, ShelterBuddy, Petestablished · WolfPack PRD \$9 scale target.

WHY NOW

Four things just became true.

01 The capacity crisis peaked, and foster became the accepted release valve.

Large-dog length of stay is at record highs. Shelter leadership is actively looking for foster growth, not another database.

02 AI got good at turning unstructured input into structured records.

A 20-second voice note is now a weight reading, a behavioural flag, and a searchable transcript. That was not true three years ago.

03 The incumbents are records systems designed before the smartphone.

PetPoint, Chameleon and ShelterBuddy have foster status fields. None of them have a foster product.

04 Social is where fosters actually come from — and nobody has instrumented it.

Every placement is content. Today that content leaks into private camera rolls instead of recruiting the next foster.

Everyone tracks fosters. Nobody grows them.

Player	Position	Foster capability	The gap we exploit
PetPoint	Enterprise records system; municipal and large shelters. Quote-based.	Foster assignment and status tracking against the animal record.	A records system, not a care system. No searchable roster, no matching, nowhere to put behaviour.
Shelterluv	Modern SaaS, mobile-first, popular with foster-centric orgs.	Best-in-class foster comms and workflow automation.	Still coordinator-driven. No compatibility matching, no behavioural journal, no acquisition loop.
ShelterBuddy / Chameleon	Enterprise and animal control. Deep compliance and configurability.	Foster lifecycle linked to medical and kennel records.	Configuration-heavy and desk-bound. Nothing designed for the foster's phone.
RescueGroups / Petstablished	API-first and SMB SaaS. Transparent, low-cost tiers.	Foster tracking plus lifecycle automation.	Thin on the human side: no onboarding programme, no retention mechanics, no matching.
Doobert	Volunteer and transport network layered on other systems.	Transport scheduling and volunteer matching.	A point solution. It never holds the dog's history, so it can't compound.
Spreadsheets + group texts	The real incumbent, and the honest one.	Whatever the coordinator remembers.	Free, instant, and where most foster coordination genuinely happens today.

POSITIONING

We compete on the foster lifecycle, not on record-keeping.

TABLE STAKES — EVERYONE HAS IT

- Intake and outcome records
- Medical and vaccination history
- Kennel and location tracking
- Adoption workflow
- Foster status field
- SAC and board reporting exports

ONLY US

- Searchable foster + volunteer roster
- AI dog↔foster and dog↔volunteer matching
- Behavioural journal that writes the profile
- Tiered onboarding with mentor pairing
- Cross-tenant public forum (reach + SEO)
- Consented social pipeline that recruits

Defensibility: the journal is a proprietary behavioural dataset that compounds per dog and per shelter. Records are commoditised. The narrative is not.

Four pillars on one record.

01

System of record

Replaces PetPoint outright. Intake
→ kennel → medical → outcome →
microchip → regulatory reporting.
Soft-delete only, full audit log,
point-in-time reconstruction.

02

Foster & volunteer database

The thing that does not exist
today. Skills, certifications,
availability, travel radius, capacity,
reliability history — searchable,
current, and the input to matching.

03

Journal + intelligence

Voice-first, offline-first capture.
Fosters, volunteers, vets and staff
all write one timeline. AI proposes
evidence-linked profile updates;
the profile writes itself.

04

Community & reach

A publicly readable cross-tenant
forum plus a consented social
share pipeline. Knowledge pooling
for retention, organic reach for
acquisition.

Native mobile for fosters and volunteers. Web dashboard for admins. Multi-tenant from day one. Quiet by default — the product is fully usable with push turned off.

15 capabilities. Six ship at pilot. AI drafts, humans decide.

SHIPS AT PILOT — 6

- AI-1 Dynamic profile assembly — behavioural flags inferred from the journal, with linked evidence
- AI-2 Structured extraction — voice and free text → weight, meals, meds, symptoms; photos auto-tagged
- AI-3 Transcription — audio and video become searchable history
- AI-4 Matching — three-layer dog↔foster and dog↔volunteer compatibility with plain-language rationale
- AI-5 Smart intake — breed and age estimation, document OCR, duplicate and return detection
- AI-14 Forum safety — PII detection and emergency interception. A gate, not a feature.

POST-PILOT — 9, EACH FLAG-CONTROLLED

- AI-6 Health-trend anomaly detection → early warning
- AI-7 Symptom triage assist — advisory only, never diagnostic
- AI-8 Length-of-stay risk prediction
- AI-9 Placement-failure early warning from check-in sentiment
- AI-10 Capacity forecasting from intake patterns
- AI-11 Adoption profile generation from the journal
- AI-12 Natural-language search across animals, people and records
- AI-13 Report generation — SAC matrix and board narratives
- AI-15 Duplicate-question detection in the forum

Guardrails: every output carries its evidence, a confidence band and accept / reject / edit. Every capability has a non-AI fallback and an independent kill switch. Sustained acceptance below 50% turns a capability off. No PII is ever sent to a model.

Every capability points at a funnel stage.

Funnel stage	What we automate	Effect on capacity
Acquisition	Consented one-tap social share pipeline; publicly readable, SEO-indexed forum	Organic inbound fosters at zero staff time. Reach becomes measurable.
Onboarding	Templated tiered Care Programs that schedule themselves; no PDF packets	Target: approved to first placement in under 24 hours.
First placement	AI-4 three-layer matching with plain-language rationale, human-decided	Right dog first time. Fewer failed placements, fewer scarred beginners.
First 72 hours	Prompted journaling, mentor pairing, one-tap concern escalation to a human	The beginner is never alone at 9pm. This is the retention lever.
Ongoing care	AI-2 and AI-3 turn a 20-second voice note into structured records	Check-ins complete in under 30 seconds. Journaling actually happens.
Retention	Quiet-by-default policy; missed check-ins escalate to a coordinator, never to the foster	Experienced fosters stop churning from notification fatigue.
Adoption	AI-1 dynamic profile and AI-11 adopter narrative drawn from real observations	Shorter length of stay. The kennel and the foster home both free up sooner.

4.8 coordinator hours back, per fostered dog.

Coordinator activity	Today	With The Foster Pack	Saved
Finding and matching a foster	45 min of broadcast texts and calls	6 min — AI shortlist, in-app offer	39 min
Beginner onboarding and hand-holding	90 min of calls, emails, PDF packets	15 min — tiered programme runs itself	75 min
Chasing weekly check-ins (4-week stay)	80 min of reminders and follow-up	15 min — exception-only escalation	65 min
Filling two support tasks (transport, supplies)	70 min of group-text brokerage	6 min — volunteers self-serve the marketplace	64 min
Building the adoption profile	40 min writing from memory	8 min — AI draft from the journal	32 min
Reporting share per dog (SAC, board)	12 min of manual assembly	1 min — auto-generated	11 min
Total per fostered dog	5.6 hours	0.85 hours	–85%

Modelled on a four-week average foster stay at SFSPCA scale. Baselines are captured before launch (PRD §4); the committed year-one target is a conservative ≥40% reduction in coordinator hours per fostered dog.

WHAT THAT BUYS

1.2 coordinators, handed back.

For a shelter placing 40 dogs into foster each month — and the coordinator is the actual constraint on how many foster homes a shelter can run.

4.8 hrs

saved per fostered dog

Across matching, onboarding, check-ins and reporting

192 hrs

returned every month

At 40 foster placements per month

2,300 hrs

returned every year

Roughly 1.2 full-time coordinators

~0 min

monthly SAC reporting

From six hours of manual assembly

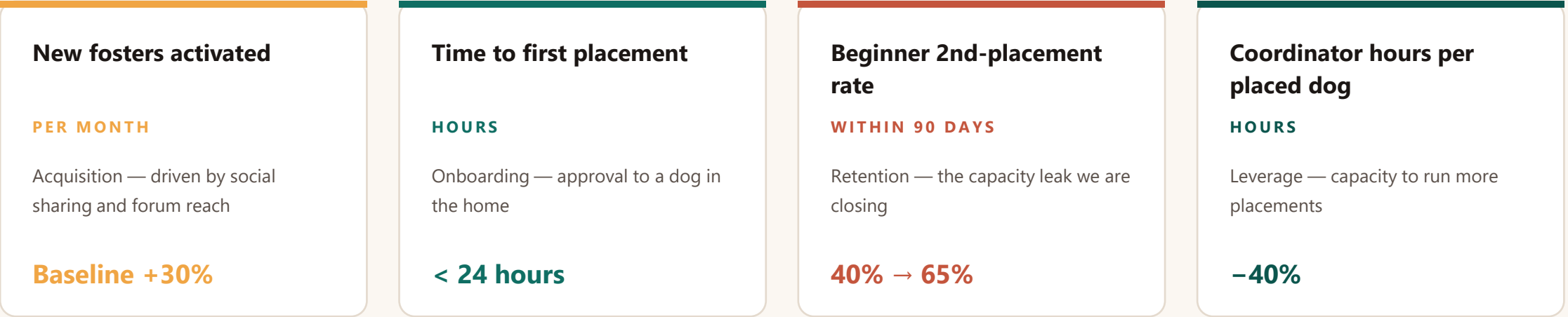
We are not asking shelters to hire. We are giving them a coordinator back — and then using that coordinator to grow the foster base.

KEY METRICS

Northstar: Foster Care Nights Delivered.

Total nights dogs spend in foster homes per shelter, per month. It only rises when we recruit more fosters, onboard them faster, keep them past placement #1, and free coordinator time to run more placements.

THE FOUR INPUTS THAT MOVE IT



Chosen because it is capacity expressed in the unit a shelter actually feels — a night a dog did not spend in a kennel, or in no home at all.

KEY METRICS TO TRACK

What we instrument from day one.

The §4 metrics are unmeasurable retroactively, so instrumentation is a milestone-one deliverable, not a later addition.

Group	Metric	Definition	Target
Core bet	Volunteer task fill rate	Published tasks claimed before deadline	≥ 90%
Core bet	Roster currency	Volunteers and fosters with current availability on file	≥ 80%
Core bet	Match acceptance rate	System-suggested matches accepted without override	Rising
Foster health	Journalling adoption	Active fosters posting ≥ 3 entries a week	Launch KPI #1
Foster health	Check-in compliance	Required check-ins completed on time, by tier	Beginner ≥ 85%
Foster health	Failed placement rate	Placements returned early	Falling
Shelter ops	Length of stay	Days from intake to adoption	–15%
Shelter ops	Record completeness	Intake, medical, microchip and outcome fully populated	≥ 95%
AI health	Suggestion acceptance rate	Accepted ÷ (accepted + rejected), per capability	Kill switch < 50%

+118 dogs a year, per shelter.

Modelled on the SFSPCA-scale seed: 250 dogs, 120 fosters, 200 volunteers, 45-day average length of stay.

A

More durable foster homes

Social and forum reach lifts recruitment 60 → 78 new fosters a year. Fast onboarding, mentor pairing and week-one support lift the second-placement rate from 40% to 65%.

Durable homes: 24 → 51 (+27)
At ~3 placements per home per year

+81 dogs into foster

B

Faster adoptions free the building

Evidence-linked behavioural profiles and better first-time matching cut length of stay by 15% across 250 dogs.

11,250 kennel-days → 1,690 days freed
At 45 days per dog

+37 dogs through the same kennels

C

Compounding effect

1.2 coordinators handed back are reinvested into recruitment and support, which raises A again the following year.

Year two builds on a larger, better-retained base — the model above is deliberately single-year and does not price this in.

Not counted in the +118

Assumptions stated deliberately: recruitment uplift, retention uplift and length-of-stay reduction are modelled projections to be validated against SFSPCA baselines captured before launch.

LIVES IMPACT AT SCALE

~5,900 dogs a year

118 additional dogs per shelter, across the 50-tenant platform design target. Roughly 320,000 dogs are euthanised in US shelters annually, and space and length of stay are the leading drivers.

**Every durable foster home is a kennel that never had to be built —
and a dog that never had to run out of time.**

Eight milestones. Dependency-ordered, not scope-cut.

	Milestone	Focus
M1	Foundation	Tenancy, identity, mobile shell, seed data, AI platform, analytics instrumented from day one
M2	Shelter core	Intake → location → medical → outcomes → reporting. PetPoint importer built here, not at cutover
M3	Core bet	Volunteer and foster database, task marketplace, inbox
M4	Journalling	Voice-first capture, media pipeline, dynamic dog profile
M5	Intelligence & ops	AI matching, tiered Care Programs, admin dashboard
M6	Community	Public forum, moderation and safety gate, Instagram sharing
M7	Migration & pilot	PetPoint historical import, parallel run, SFSPCA foster cohort
M8	GA	Localisation (Spanish, Traditional Chinese), accessibility audit, moderation staffed

Staff these first: WS-0 blocks everything and WS-17 (AI platform) blocks six streams. Under-resourcing either stalls the project regardless of headcount elsewhere.

WHAT COULD BREAK THIS

Three critical risks, designed against.

Fosters don't journal

The whole thesis collapses — the profile never materialises and the AI has nothing to reason over.

MITIGATION

Extreme capture-friction reduction: zero required fields, voice-first, offline-first, prompted rather than blank-box. Measured weekly as launch KPI #1.

The public forum causes harm

Medical advice at public scale is a genuine liability and a genuine safety risk.

MITIGATION

Non-dismissible disclaimers, keyword emergency interception before publication, verified vet and staff badges, coordinator alerting, legal review before launch.

Foster PII leaks

Home addresses exposed on a public forum is a personal-safety risk, not a compliance footnote.

MITIGATION

Automatic PII scrubbing pre-publication, unconditional EXIF and geolocation stripping on ingest, addresses restricted to admins, foster education at onboarding.

And one standing obligation: we are a system of record now. Soft-delete only, point-in-time reconstruction of any animal record, and restore drills rehearsed quarterly — not assumed.

THE ASK

Fund the pilot. Prove the funnel.

01 Approve the SFSPCA pilot cohort — and capture baselines first.

Coordinator hours, foster retention and length of stay cannot be measured retroactively. Baseline capture is a prerequisite, not a phase.

02 Settle the seven blocking decisions.

Stack, hosting, model provider and self-hosting posture, PetPoint cutover and parallel-run exit criteria.

03 Staff platform and shelter operations properly, and start the forum legal track on day one.

Never under-staff T1 or T4. The forum's policy work begins at M1 regardless of when its engineering does.

Every dog's story, written by everyone who cares for them.